



Smart Kitchen

Family Guide

For Andrew & Leslie's Family • Liz & Kyle's Family

smart-kitchen-opal.vercel.app

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Version 2.0 • April 2026

How This App Started

This app started with a question I dreaded hearing.

My wife has been dealing with a health condition that keeps her from doing much of the cooking. I took that over without a second thought — it's what you do. But after a full day of work, making decisions all day, I'd walk through the door already running on empty.

"What's for dinner?"

I'd get irritated. Not at her — never at her. Just at the question itself. That one more decision at the end of a day when I had nothing left to give. I didn't want to feel that way. I knew it wasn't fair. But I couldn't seem to stop it.

Around the same time I was exploring how AI could fit into real daily life — not as a tech experiment, but as something genuinely useful. I kept asking: what friction points in my day could I actually hand off?

That question was one of them.

The Idea

What if the app just knew what was for dinner?

What if it looked at what was already in the kitchen, knew who it was cooking for, knew which nights were crazy busy and which ones had time to spare — and just handled it?

Not a recipe website. A system that thinks ahead so the person doing the cooking doesn't have to.

That's Smart Kitchen. Built by a husband who does the cooking, for anyone who's ever stood in front of the refrigerator at 6 PM too tired to think.

You two families are my first real-world testers. Your feedback — what works, what doesn't, what you wish it did differently — is what shapes what gets built next.

Text me anything. Good or bad.

— *Rick*

Welcome to Smart Kitchen

Smart Kitchen is your family's AI-powered kitchen assistant. It figures out what to cook, keeps track of what's in your fridge, freezer, and pantry, builds a full week of dinner plans, and generates your grocery list — all in one place.

No app to download. It runs right in your phone's browser. Open it and you're ready to go.

What It Can Do

Recipe Suggestions	Get meal ideas based on what's already in your kitchen. Type a few ingredients or let the app scan your inventory.
Receipt Scanner	Point your camera at a grocery receipt — the app reads it and logs your ingredients automatically.
Inventory Scanner	Scan items directly from your fridge, freezer, and pantry shelves. Labels facing forward works best.
7-Day Meal Plan	One tap generates a full week of dinners tailored to your family's size, schedule, and dietary needs.
Busy Night Flag	Mark hectic evenings and the app automatically schedules a quick 20-minute meal for that night.
Shopping List	Auto-generated from your meal plan — grouped by store section and ready to print or use on your phone.
Google Calendar	Push your weekly meal plan straight to Google Calendar so the whole family sees what's for dinner.
Desserts	Get dessert ideas from your pantry and baking supplies — On Hand and Needed badges on every ingredient.



Add It to Your Home Screen

Make it feel like a regular app with one tap to open — no typing the address every time.

iPhone: tap the Share button in Safari → 'Add to Home Screen.'

Android: tap the three-dot menu in Chrome → 'Add to Home Screen.'

Getting Started — Setup Wizard

The first time you open Smart Kitchen, a Setup Wizard walks you through everything. It takes about five minutes and sets up your family profile, dietary needs, and starting inventory so the app is ready to cook for your household from day one.

Welcome & Preview Screens

The welcome screen introduces the app. A Setup Preview screen then shows all the wizard steps so you know what's coming. Tap Get Started when ready, or Skip Setup to go straight to the app and set things up later.

Step 1 — Family Profile & All Dietary Needs

Everything about who the app is cooking for lives in Step 1. Your household details, food preferences, dietary restrictions, medical needs, and any temporary diet requirements — all set here once and applied automatically going forward.

Household Setup

1

Enter your household name

Something like 'Andrew & Leslie' or 'Liz & Kyle.'

2

Set number of people and age ranges

Toddlers, kids, teens, and adults all eat different portions. The app scales accordingly.

3

Select proteins your family eats

Chicken, Beef, Pork, Fish, Seafood, Turkey, Vegetarian, and more. Tap each that applies.

Dietary Restrictions — Permanent

Check off anything that applies to your household on an ongoing basis. The app enforces these automatically — no reminders needed.

- Gluten-Free, Dairy-Free, Nut Allergy, Vegetarian, Vegan, Low Carb, and more
- These apply to every recipe suggestion and meal plan from this point forward
- The app substitutes ingredients automatically — it doesn't just flag them

Medical Dietary Needs — Permanent

For medically-managed diets, the app enforces them at the AI level with automatic ingredient substitutions throughout every meal plan.

Diabetic-Friendly	Lower glycemic ingredients, whole grains, reduced sugars.
Heart-Healthy	Low sodium, low saturated fat, heart-supportive choices.
Low Sodium	Reduced salt throughout all recipes and meal plans.
Renal Diet	Restricted potassium, phosphorus, and sodium.
Anti-Inflammatory	Whole foods, healthy fats, anti-inflammatory ingredients.

✓ How It Works for Kyle

Kyle's diabetic-friendly profile means the app automatically uses:

- Brown rice instead of white rice
- Whole wheat pasta instead of regular
- Lower glycemic ingredient substitutions throughout
- Reduced sodium across all recipes

These happen without anyone asking. Every recipe. Every meal plan.

Temporary Medical Diets

For short-term dietary changes — set a duration and the profile deactivates automatically when time's up.

Surgery Prep	Low-fiber or reduced-residue diet before a procedure.
Post-Op Recovery	Soft foods and easily digestible meals during healing.
Medication Diet	Avoid foods that interact with specific medications.
Elimination Diet	Remove ingredients temporarily to identify sensitivities.
Short-Term Program	A dietitian-prescribed plan or 30-day health challenge.

💊 One Setup. Always Applied.

Everything in Step 1 is set once and remembered permanently.

You won't be asked for this information again.

Every recipe suggestion and meal plan reflects your family's needs automatically.

Step 2 — How to Add Inventory

1

Scan a Receipt

Point your camera at a grocery receipt. Fastest option right after a shopping run.

2

Scan Shelf Items

Walk through your kitchen and scan items directly from shelves, fridge, or freezer. Labels need

to be clearly visible.

3

Add Manually

Type items in by hand — good for produce, butcher meat, or anything without a scannable label.

4

Set Up Later

Skip for now and go straight to the app. Add inventory anytime from the main menu.

Steps 3–6 — Proteins, Recipe Sites, Pantry Setup & Checklist

The remaining steps are quick. Choose your family's proteins (already set in Step 1 but confirmed here), pick your favorite recipe websites, decide how to handle pantry staples, and check off what you already have on hand. The pantry checklist is a great starting point for recipe suggestions even before your first receipt scan.



Pantry Checklist Tip

At the end of the wizard, Smart Kitchen asks if you'd like to add missing pantry staples to your shopping list.

Tap Yes for a ready-to-use starter list before your next grocery run.

Managing Your Inventory

The more accurate your inventory, the better the recipe suggestions and meal plans. Here's how to keep it current.

Scanning Grocery Receipts

1

Tap 'Scan Receipt' from the home screen

Opens your camera in receipt scanning mode.

2

Lay the receipt flat in good light

Shadows and crumples make it harder to read. Natural light works best.

3

Capture and review

The app lists detected food items. Remove anything misread.

4

Check expiry dates

Firm dates are read from the label. When no date is printed, the app shows an estimated shelf life (shown as ~est.) based on product type.

5

Tap 'Add to Inventory'

All confirmed items are saved.

Scanning Shelf & Package Items — Counter Method

Instead of photographing a full shelf, pull items out and line them up on a clear counter with labels facing forward. This is the most accurate approach.

**Labels Need to Be Clearly Visible**

The app reads what it can see. Labels turned away, crumpled, or hidden won't scan.

Set items on a clear counter — like a little grocery store shelf — before scanning.

Frozen items are fine out of the freezer for the 2-3 minutes it takes.

Tips by Location

- Refrigerator — pull items to the front edge of shelves so labels face out. Condiments in the door scan easily.
- Freezer — boxes and bags scan very well. Smooth out crumpled bags first.
- Pantry — cans, boxes, and jars are the easiest. Group by type for best results.
- Produce & Bulk Items — no scannable labels. Add these manually.

Manual Add & Category Pills

For items the scanner can't read, type them in quickly with a category tag to keep inventory organized.

1

Tap 'Add Item'

A simple text entry opens.

2

Type what you have

'carrots', '1 lb ground beef', 'half bag brown rice.'

3

Tap a category pill

Produce, Meat, Dairy, Pantry, Frozen, Baking, Leftovers, etc.

4

Set a location (optional)

Fridge, Freezer, or Pantry — so you always know where to find it.

Inline Editing — Fix Category or Location on the Card

If an item ends up in the wrong category, fix it right on the inventory card — no need to delete and re-add.

- Tap any item in your inventory to expand the card
- Tap the category pill or location tag directly on the card
- Select the correct option — changes apply instantly

Baking Category

There's a dedicated Baking category for ingredients used in baking and desserts — flour, sugar, chocolate chips, vanilla, baking soda, and more. Items tagged as Baking feed directly into the Desserts recipe section so the app knows what you can make tonight.

Wednesday & Sunday Review Reminders

Smart Kitchen sends a reminder twice a week to do a quick 2-minute inventory check. Sunday sets you up for the week ahead. Wednesday catches mid-week changes. Two check-ins keeps your inventory accurate enough to trust.

Meal Planning

One tap generates a full 7-day dinner plan for your family — tailored to your dietary needs, your inventory, and the pace of your week. Takes about 15 seconds.

Generating Your Week

1

Tap 'Meal Plan' from the home screen

Opens the meal planning screen.

2

Your family profile loads automatically

Dietary restrictions and preferences are already set from Step 1.

3

Add any notes (optional)

'Include one pasta night' or 'nothing with shellfish this week.'

4

Tap 'Generate Meal Plan'

Seven dinners appear — one for each day of the week.

Reading the Meal Plan Card

- Day of the week and meal name
- One-line description of the dish
- Estimated prep and cook time
- Quick Meal badge for dinners under 30 minutes
- Busy Night flag if you've marked that evening

Tap any card to open the full recipe — ingredients, step-by-step instructions, and On Hand / Needed badges on every ingredient.

Change Meal

Don't like what the app picked? Swap just that night without regenerating the whole week.

- Surprise Me — the app picks something completely different
- Specific Request — type what you're in the mood for: 'something with salmon' or 'slow cooker'

Busy Night / Quick Meal Flag

Mark the hectic evenings — practices, games, activities — and Smart Kitchen automatically schedules a quick, easy dinner for that night.

1

Tap the flag icon next to any day

A menu appears.

2

Select 'Busy Night'

That dinner is replaced with a Quick Meal — under 30 minutes, one pan, or slow-cooker.

3

Rest of the week stays the same

Only the flagged night changes.

**Built for Active Families**

Between practices, games, and activities across multiple kids, some nights dinner just needs to be fast and on the table. Flag those nights and let Smart Kitchen handle the planning.

Made It! — Updating Inventory After Cooking

When you finish cooking a meal from the plan, tap Made It! on the card. Smart Kitchen automatically removes the used ingredients from your inventory — no manual updating needed.

Sending to Google Calendar

1

Tap 'Send to Calendar' after generating your plan

Appears at the bottom of the meal plan screen.

2

Sign in with Google if prompted

The app only needs permission to add events — it can't read your other calendar items.

3

Each dinner appears as an event

'Dinner: [Meal Name]' on each day of the week — visible to the whole family.

Shopping List

Your shopping list is built automatically from your meal plan. Anything you need that isn't in your inventory goes on the list. Items are grouped by category — Produce, Meat, Dairy, Pantry, Baking, Frozen — so you can shop each section without backtracking.

- Tap items as you put them in the cart to check them off
- Add items manually for anything not on the list
- Tap Print for a clean formatted list to take to the store

Recipes & Desserts

Getting Recipe Suggestions

Smart Kitchen generates recipe ideas based on what's already in your kitchen. Two ways to get them:

- From Your Inventory — tap 'Get Recipe Ideas' and the app pulls from what you have on hand
- Type What You Have — type a few ingredients: 'chicken thighs, broccoli, garlic' and the app builds recipes around those

For big households, add it to your request: 'feeding 8 people including teens and a toddler.' The app scales portions and notes toddler-friendly adaptations where relevant.

On Hand vs. Needed Badges

Every ingredient in a recipe is tagged so you know exactly what you have and what you still need:

On Hand	You already have this. No shopping needed.
Needed	Tap to add this ingredient directly to your shopping list.

Tap I Cooked This when done — the app removes the used ingredients from your inventory automatically.

Desserts

The Desserts section works exactly like Recipes — just focused on sweet treats. It draws from your Baking category inventory specifically, so the more stocked your baking shelf is, the better the suggestions.

- Tap 'Desserts' from the home screen
- On Hand and Needed badges show on every ingredient
- Tap 'I Cooked This' when done to update inventory automatically



Quick Tip

Keep flour, sugar, eggs, butter, and chocolate chips stocked in your Baking category and you'll almost always have what you need for a simple weeknight dessert.

Try typing 'quick dessert with pantry staples' for easy ideas.

Quick Reference

App URL

smart-kitchen-opal.vercel.app

Common Questions

Do I need to create an account?

No. Smart Kitchen doesn't require a login. Just open the URL and start using it.

Does it cost anything?

No. The app is free for family use. Rick covers the hosting and AI costs.

Does it work without WiFi?

No — the AI runs in the cloud so an internet connection is required.

What if the scanner misreads an item?

After every scan the app shows what it detected before adding anything. Review the list and remove anything misread. You can also tap any item in your inventory and fix the category or name right on the card.

What are the expiry dates I see on items?

Firm dates are read directly from the label. Estimated hints (shown as ~est.) are the app's best guess based on product type when no date is printed. Always use your own judgment with perishables.

Can the teens use it on their own?

Absolutely — that's encouraged. If a teen wants to find something to make for lunch or help with dinner, they can use the recipe feature on their own phone. The simpler the ingredients they type in, the more straightforward the suggestions.

What if something doesn't work?

Text Rick. Screenshots of any error messages are really helpful. Your feedback is literally how the app gets better.

Questions, feedback, or something not working — text or call Rick directly.
Screenshots help. Detailed descriptions of what you were doing help even more.

This app is built for your families.
Your real-world feedback is what shapes what gets built next.